

KF9 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Try me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any hurtful way in me, and lead me in everlasting ways.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

After you have practiced the **Maranatha Meditation** for a while, you will find it a helpful tool when your Idol employs its tactics to derail your mind. For example, when self-hate torments you with anxiety or condemning thoughts, when your mind is wasting energy on vain imaginations or obsessive thinking, when you feel a craving to default to old unhealthy patterns, or when you are too excited or euphoric—in all these situations, *Maranatha (O Lord, come!)* can give you some peace from the stories and thoughts that lead to more suffering.

The Maranatha Meditation¹

Begin by sitting still and as upright as you can. Prop yourself up with pillows if you cannot sit up comfortably. Breathe as you lightly close your eyes. *(Pause)* Your mind may not be focused right now, but don't let that discourage you. One of the benefits of meditation is that it provides a safe opportunity to practice endurance. So, if you feel frustrated, congratulate yourself for exercising endurance. Try not to judge the level of your meditation skills. Meditation is a discipline that requires training and patient effort. Be kind to yourself as a learner.

Now, silently, within your own mind, begin to slowly say the word MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA. If your mind wanders, gently draw it back to the word, without judgment. To help you endure, I will remind you of the word once during our three-minute meditation. Relax into the word as you breathe, and begin. MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA. *(Pause for 3 minutes with a reminder of the word after 1.5 minutes)*

Pause, and listen to our hymn and prayer, *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord*.

When doubts and fears arise, teach me Thy way!
When storms o'erspread the skies, teach me Thy way!
Shine through the cloud and rain, through sorrow, toil and pain;
Make Thou my pathway plain, teach me Thy way!²

Take a deep breath and open your eyes. You might begin practicing this meditation for twenty minutes

each morning and then again later in the day. If you have little ones who need you, practice for five minutes several times a day. Use a timer or a meditation app to help you relax and disengage from a sense of passing time.

In a more precise and elegant form of English than we now speak, to address someone using the word *thou* indicated intimacy and a close family relationship. To address someone as *you* was considered formal and polite. Isn't it strange that today *thou* sounds so formal and so religious, when in reality it describes a very close human relationship?

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month our focus is on KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by our Creator

Over the last few weeks we have been looking at the **Two Paths Flowchart**. This tool helps us recognize the sequence of choices that lead from an event to an outcome. Using the same amount of energy, we can choose the path toward God's glory or the path toward the Idol's glory. The lower path charts the mechanical, programmed reactions that we depend upon for saving our Idol's life. However, we can train ourselves to take the upper path of love, even when we feel the fear of death. Here are some points to consider as you explore this flowchart.

1. Judging good or evil

If an event supports our search for idealized glory, we will automatically judge it as good; if an event threatens our idealized glory, we will automatically judge it as evil. When the Idol is threatened, we feel the fear of death. We then react like wild animals, and we react in predictable ways. Our reactions feel rational and authentic, but in reality, we are simply defending our Idol Self.

2. Train hard, fight easy

The **Two Paths Flowchart** helps us explore step by step the path that we have taken. With diligent training, we can change our path. We can retrain our minds to think according to the path of love and then choose to act in ways that benefit both ourselves and others. By doing so, we foster our connection to God and our harmony—or cooperation—with the Creation. Remember that you and your community are also created things and part of the Creation.

3. Our emotional reactions are not trustworthy guides for making decisions

Our feelings often distort our perception of reality, and it might be distressing to learn that we cannot depend on our emotional reactions to help us make healthy decisions. At this stage in our training, all immediate and extreme reactions are suspect. If an event frightens us into reacting with rage, hurt, stagnation, self-defense, retreat, depression, or addictive choices, we have already told a story about why that event is evil. Why is it evil? It is evil because it has not met our compelling needs. We then try to restore our hurt pride by blaming others or ourselves. We attack or appease others; we are driven to build them up or take them down. We withdraw or control, act crazy, get sick, or give up. If

an event relieves us from the fear of death, we feel euphoric and have a story in place about why the event is good. In euphoria, we become mindless and forget that we have limitations. We forget that in every situation we have a Lord to serve, and we make choices that lead to misoriented outcomes. In order to recover from this misorientation, we have to expend a great deal of our resources—resources that could be dedicated to the goal of actualizing our glorious potential. Expending our resources for recovery isn't always a bad thing, however. In fact, it is necessary to expend resources to recover orientation. Nevertheless, recovery from misorientation is an inefficient use of our resources, especially when we might have prevented the problem in the first place by refusing to judge.

4. Judgments are based on our own legal systems, or law

The more we derive our sense of self-confidence from fulfilling our shoulds, taboos, and claims, the more we are compelled to react to adverse events, and the force of our emotions reveals how badly we need to protect our sense of security, self-value, and pride. The more committed we are to the Idol, the less flexible we are when we fall into various experiments that stir up fear. So, you can pretty well determine the level of your commitment to the Idol Self by how rigidly you react to life's events. Do you find yourself reacting in the same way over and over again? Are you, as James says, unstable in your ways and easily unbalanced by events? Are you unable to think clearly, creatively, or rationally when upset? Are you immediately overwhelmed with feelings that you then use to justify your behavior? Do you find yourself attacking or sabotaging yourself or others? Are you falling back into addictive behaviors? The inability to control your reactions tells you something about the Idol's grip on your life.

The Idol pursues its imagined glory with secret strategies and, like any secret system, keeps its members in the fog about what is really going on. The book study invites you to come out of the fog of neurosis with its deceit and illusions. Coming out of the fog is a difficult process, but with humility and training you can learn to watch for signs of idolatry, such as compulsive and habitual reactions, inflexibility, and extreme emotions. It is in your best interest to be on the watch. You are in a position of strength when you know your enemy.

5. There is no condemnation in Jesus³

There are lots of reasons why you have learned to react as you do, but knowing those reasons is not as helpful to you as finding the solutions. That's why you are in Karis Fellowships—to find solutions. Let me encourage you not to motivate yourself with judgment and self-condemnation during your KF healing process. By doing so, you just set up the judgment path again, and you were not designed to live that way. Accept that you are dealing with a combination of healthy and unhealthy forces; you are both growing and resisting growth. Step back and simply observe your feelings and behavior in a detached manner, like a researcher. Be patient with yourself. Work on your weaknesses and acknowledge your strengths. Take time to work, and take time to rest.

Acknowledge with compassion your commitment to the Idol Self and the compelling intensity of your need to save your life from fear. I suggest that you go back through the chapter in *Neurosis and Human Growth* that describes your Idol type and make a list of your hot spots.⁴ Creating that list may take you several days or several weeks. Take it easy. Explore gently.

6. Your fears correlate with your Idol type

Perhaps you can already see the correlation between your fears and your Idol type. Self-effacing types fear taking charge of their own life; they feel safer as victims and look for someone stronger to lean

on. They fear doing anything expansive that draws attention to themselves. Mastery types fear vulnerability and loss of control; they are terrified of feeling helpless and becoming someone's victim. Resigned types fear restriction, imposition, and any change, even in themselves.

7. The fight with the Idol Self is the right fight

Paul felt so much self-confidence at the end of his life that he could say, *"I have fought the good fight."*⁵ (Repeat) The good fight is the right fight, and defending your Idol's pride system is not the right fight. The right fight is against your Idol Self. Through your work in KF, you are fighting on the side of truth and the True Self—and the God of truth is fighting for you. You are probing the secret strategies of the real enemy, your Idol Self. *Learn to look for progress, not perfection.* (Repeat) Be patient with your own process. Endure the difficulties of training as you develop your skills. You are not looking for the reasons for your fears right now. You are simply training hard to observe your fears and reactions with compassion.

Thanks to everyone who sent me a list of their three greatest fears, but if you haven't done so yet, there is still time to send them. Email me at nancy@karisfellowships.com. We will take a look at our fears in the next few weeks.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, reveal the fears that harm me. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Last week, we talked about the person of single spirit. As a side note, the word for *spirit* in many ancient Indo-European languages is also the word for *breath*. Ancient cultures had a very clear understanding of the connection between breath and spirit. When we are single-spirit people, our breath and choices flow together in harmony. We can use the breath to calm our minds and prepare ourselves to make mindful, oriented choices, which over time will repattern our reactions.

Let's look again at KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by our Creator.

We will move away from James for a while and talk about the glory that we have abandoned. You were designed to express the glory of God through manifesting the truth of who He created you to be—and that truth is your glory in Christ. Through your KF training, you will begin to reveal this glory that is uniquely yours.

1. Learn to live joyfully in the material world as a spiritual creature

Whether you are consciously aware of it or not, your True Self desires to live in continual communion and correspondence, or co-respondence, with its Creator. It was designed for that relationship, with no confusion about who the Creator is—you or God. The True Self wants to live out its life joyfully and

in constant gratitude, submitting to all the limitations of being a creature while discovering the glory of what is possible.

2. **Your True Self is an eternally creative creature**

You are created in the image of the Creator who creates. The person that you build and the contributions of your creative nature are gifts to heaven and to earth. When you live out of the True Self, you are undivided. From that single spirit, you will develop a deep security and peace which will be expressed in power, a contributing livelihood, generous gratitude, and vitally connected relationships. The whole New Testament declares this potential that is yours.

3. **Our personal glory expresses the love of God in this world in a unique way**

Your potential is “love from a pure heart, a good conscience, and a sincere faith”. That pithy statement is found in First Timothy 1:5. Translation is a difficult business, but through the following paraphrase I hope to convey a fuller understanding of what Paul is saying here.

Agape love flows from a healthy mental and emotional function, from a co-understanding with God that generates goodness, and from all of the powerful reorienting influence that naturally springs out of the authority of our trustworthiness before God and our trust in Him.

In KF, we do not compare our potential with that of other people. Your potential is built on the reality of your physical body, your genetics, your energetic patterns, and your antecedents, all of which are unique and all of which carry their own limitations. Comparing yourself to others reveals your ignorance about the unique potential that each of us has. Your antecedents are everything that has come before and has contributed to who you are today—your family, education, history, and choices. We can enhance the potential of those around us, and in particular the potential of our children, by providing supportive antecedents that they can build upon. In fact, every interaction with another person can become an antecedent that influences their future and shows them something about God.

I first learned the principle of non-comparison in a yoga class. I do not have a flexible body, and I used to compare my abilities with those of others in the class. However, making those comparisons did nothing to help me become more flexible. In the class, my teacher taught me how to work within my own limitations rather than look around at what others were doing. I learned to pay kind attention to myself while gently working with my own realities. I also learned to rejoice in whatever progress I had made in my body. In your KF training, you will need to cultivate the same gentle non-comparison while training your True Self.

Let’s look at a few of the qualities of love that indicate a healthy True Self. You will find a description of these qualities on the KF handout **Love or Pride?**, which you can find on the website under **Toolbox** and **Worksheets**.

We learned in **chapter 13 of First Corinthians** that love is long-tempered. It is able to maintain orientation for a long period of time under adverse circumstances, but this is more than simple endurance or patience. A long temper is the fruit of having allowed endurance to accomplish its designed purpose, which is to make you whole, fully equipped, and lacking nothing so that you can explore your true glory. Long temper is the ability to draw on all that you have gained through productive endurance.

We also see in verse 4 that love *does kindnesses*. We can choose to act kindly out of the strength of a whole, mature, and fully equipped long temper. Kindness is active goodness toward ourselves and others regardless of our feelings and regardless of the failings of others. Even when we fail in our search for glory and then experience self-hate, we can choose to be kind to ourselves and to others. In his book *The Road Less Traveled* Scott Peck writes: “Love is the will to extend oneself to nurture spiritual growth.”⁶ Paul makes this even clearer by using *kindness* as a verb: “Love *kindnesses*”. When you make the effort to actively extend yourself to nurture your own or another’s personal growth, you are showing love.

Next, let’s look at verse 7, which tells us that love *covers all things*. Your translation might say that love *bears all things*, but we can understand this verb to mean covering, just as a roof covers a house. In other words, love covers us and love covers others. So, when we cover for each other, we show love. Out of our growing magnanimity, we can proactively choose to extend generosity. When we or someone else is misoriented, we do not judge or condemn—we cover. We do not rejoice in mistakes and foolish choices to justify our vindictive triumph or appease our self-hate. For example, when someone loses something or acts out of mindlessness, we do not grab the opportunity to act superior, to punish, or to take on a victim role; instead, we step up and minimize the damage with kindness. We gently cover for each other until we can grow. Covering does not mean that we let others get away with abuse or with damaging the community. When others are hurting themselves or others, they need someone to cover for them by setting boundaries that will restrict their behavior and protect others. Covering could mean calling the police, going to court, or using anger as a defense against assault. When we hold others accountable for their choices, we are inviting them to make different choices. By holding others accountable, we cover and protect the community.

Our prayer to God might go something like this:

You who covered for me, help me cover all things, both for myself and for others. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your mindfulness posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider how you might cover and care for yourself or for another person?*
(Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider how you might cover and care for yourself or for another person, how does it feel? (Pause)
Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe and *consider how you might cover and care for yourself or for another person.* (Pause) Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore, without judgment, your real thoughts and feelings about covering. Breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider how you might cover and care.* What sensations are there? (Pause) Your body is always talking to you, even when faced with the challenge of covering. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what frustration or the long temper of mindful endurance feels like in your body. (Pause) If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider how you might cover and care.* (Pause) Do you judge that effort as good or evil, as a possibility or a bother? (Pause) What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? (Pause) Is this fear a regular pattern in your life? (Pause) If you were to cover, are you afraid of deprivation, hurt pride, losing control, or of what you might discover about yourself? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered how to cover and care for themselves or for another person.* You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. (Pause) Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. (Pause) When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for others who find it difficult to authentically *cover for another person or for themselves.* Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for this time together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth about Your love. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

² *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord* by Benjamin Mansell Ramsey (1849–1923), youtu.be/FmY6848ZQeo.

³ Rom. 8:1.

⁴ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁵ 2 Tim. 4:7.

⁶ M. Scott Peck, *The Road Less Traveled: A New Psychology of Love, Traditional Values, and Spiritual Growth* (New York: Touchstone, 1978), 119.